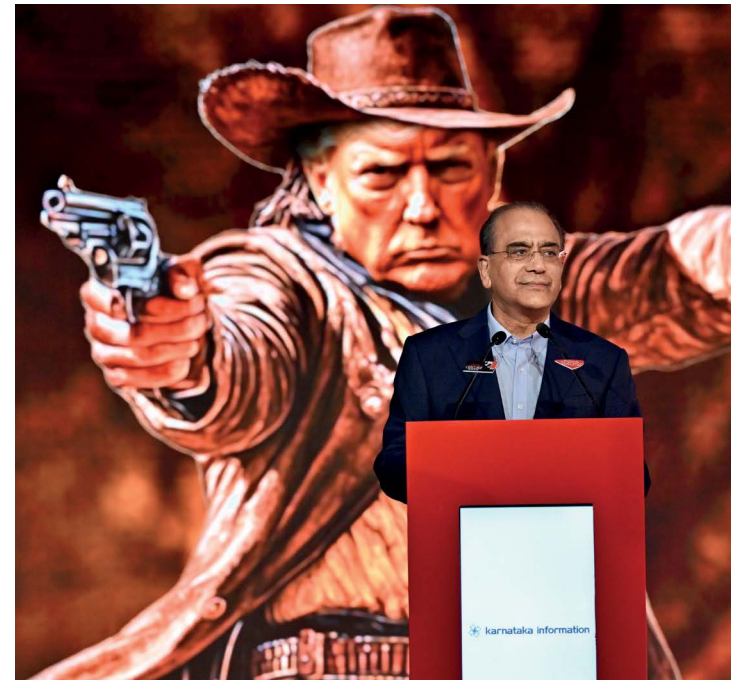


We are standing at a crossroads of history. As they say in the cowboy movies, there is a new sheriff in town. That is Donald J. Trump. And it's no small town. It is the United States of America. The world's largest economy and only superpower. And he's holding friend and foe alike at gunpoint to get a better deal.

He's bent on destroying the world order that America established after the Second World War in 1945. He's weaponising trade. He is claiming that America has been taken for a ride even by its allies. True to character, he's playing two contradictory roles. He has withdrawn America from international institutional frameworks like the WHO and the Paris Climate Accord, and I'm sure there will be more. If he perceives no financial gains for America, he wants out. On the other hand, he's behaving like a CEO of a multinational company who wants to make some acquisitions. He wants Canada to become America's 51st state, and wants to acquire the Panama Canal, Greenland and Gaza.

He also wants to end the Ukraine war by negotiating with Russia without Ukraine. All he wants Ukraine to do is give America the rights to mine its rare earth minerals in return for all the aid they have already got. Shockingly, aid is being converted into a loan without providing any security guarantees which Ukraine desperately needs. He doesn't respect the UN charter that requires countries to respect each other's territory or the global institutions where free trade rules were negotiated. The norms of civil engagement between nations and the language and protocol of diplomacy are all in a churn. The old template is cracking and is being replaced by a sense of anarchy. And he has only been in office for 47 days so far. It seems that geopolitics has turned into reality TV. So, there are interesting times ahead. As one American journalist said, "If it weren't my country, I would take out the popcorn and watch the show." Jokes apart, what America does has serious repercussions for everybody.

The theme for the Conclave is the Age of Acceleration. This means that not only does change happen, but the rate of change gets faster and faster. We could not imagine that Donald J. Trump would step on the pedal so soon to validate our theme.

Thank you, Mr President. Later today, we have Michael R. Pompeo, who was Trump's foreign secretary for nearly three years in his first term. I am sure he will share some rare insights into Donald Trump's mind and working style. We also have the US commerce secretary Howard Lutnick live via satellite to discuss the hottest topic of the day: TARIFFS. Besides the changes in America, there are other powerful forces at work that will impact our lives. In other words, technology.

In particular, the astounding increase in computing power has given birth to Artificial Intelligence. This is transforming every aspect of our lives, from the workplace to politics and even ethics. We are still struggling to determine whether it is a boon or a curse. Nevertheless, it is impossible to halt the march of technology. With Elon Musk right in the heart of the Trump administration, there is even talk of 'techno-fascism'. That is absolute power speaking in the language of technology. All aspects of government and society get technologised. The best one can do is attempt to regulate it without losing its

India is fortunate to have PM Modi on the international stage. Somebody the world takes seriously. Not a former comedian or reality TV star